

photo cartridge, containing additional colour shades. Ink level monitoring is accurate.

The printer takes up a lot of desk space. The build quality of the flaps and paper trays are good. It has a crystal-clear LCD that displays the image to be printed, and the menu structure. Dedicated buttons are available for zoom, resize, rotate, etc., making the printing process easy—you don't need to go through any menus.

Priced at Rs 16,999, the HP Photosmart 7960 is a good proposition if you need great photos.

HP Photosmart 7960	
Performance	4.0
Features	4.0
Build quality	4.0
Value for money	4.0

Refilling Cartridges

HP touched US\$3 billion in revenues from consumables (or cartridges) in 2002. This figure would have been higher if not for the refilling of cartridges, which remains a big business despite efforts by vendors to discourage it—by attempting to educate channel partners and users through articles and advertisements. The volume of ads in the print media speaks for the spread and acceptance of the business.

Vendors say refilled cartridges give low-quality prints, damage print heads, and, if leakage occurs, damage other parts. Warranties are also void if refills are used. But Praveen Khandelwal, Director of LIPAP Systems, which sells refill kits and provide refill services, claims, in typical fashion, that their ink is as good as the original, and that it's harmless. As far as quality is concerned, it depends entirely on the ink used and quality differs from refiller to refiller.

To counter refilling, Epson in the US, installed smart chips in one of its models—the Epson Stylus C60—that lock the printer once the cartridges are empty, or if the printer doesn't have an original supply. While Epson claims that by doing this it encourages users to use the original cartridge supply, customer reactions have been negative.

We contacted a local refill service provider. His prices for black and colour cartridges for the HP Deskjet 990CXi were just Rs 100 and 400 respectively. Also, refilling would take only half an hour. Using a refill kit is even cheaper, but time-consuming and messy.

Cartridges can't be refilled more than three or four times—the quality drop is significant, and the chances of damage increase. But, a cartridge set for, say, the HP Deskjet 3350 costs Rs 1,900, and the printer with its free cartridge set costs only Rs 3,000. Refillers, therefore, say that it makes more sense to buy a new printer, if you insist on original cartridges.

If you'd like to know how exactly to refill a cartridge all by yourself, be on the lookout for the May issue of Digit.

Settings Galore

We used the HP Photosmart 7960 to take a brief look at the printing options provided with the printer driver.



Use the HP Digital Photography options to tweak images

The HP Digital Photography Options is under the 'Paper/Quality' tab. It provides useful tools such as red-eye removal, smoothing and digital flash.

If you want to print with text on facing sides, enable 'Print on Both Sides' in the 'Finishing' tab. Enable 'Flip Pages Up' to create a calendar-like book. There's also a

selection mode for booklet layout, that lets you print two sheets on a page: After printing is done, fold the pages at the centre, and staple them together.



If you need to print several sheets on one page, just select the number from the dropdown box at 'Pages Per Sheet.' You can also specify the order in which pages prints.

To enlarge a page, you need to select one option from 2 x 2 (4 sheets), 3 x 3 (9 sheets), and



Manage your resources by controlling these features

watermark too—the available ones are 'DO NOT COPY', 'TOP SECRET', etc.

The 'Advanced options' helps you control ink consumption and drying time, so a sheet isn't released until the ink's dried.

The 'Color' tab lets you control 'Color Options' and 'Color Attributes,' such as printing in greyscale, saturation, etc.



Resize your image to fit the media, in the Effects tab

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